

§ 170.315(h)(1)

Direct Project

Certification Companion Guide v1.1

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This Certification Companion Guide (CCG) is an informative document designed to assist with health IT product certification. The CCG is not a substitute for the requirements outlined in regulation and related ONC final rules. It extracts key portions of ONC final rules' preambles and includes subsequent clarifying interpretations. To access the full context of regulatory intent please consult the [Certification Regulations](#) page for links to all ONC final rules or consult other regulatory references as noted. The CCG is for public use and should not be sold or redistributed.

Certification Clarifications

Technical Explanations and Clarifications

- In order to meet the Base EHR Definition, a provider would need to possess technology that has been certified to either this criterion at § 170.315(h)(1) or the “Direct Project, Edge Protocol, and XDR/XDM” criterion at § 170.315(h)(2).
- Use of the Applicability Statement for Secure Health Transport (“Direct”) is required to meet this certification criterion. There is no exemption or additional possible transport standard for certification to this criterion.
- This certification criterion uses the Applicability Statement for Secure Health Transport, Version 1.2 standard. This new version of the specification includes updates that improve interoperability through the clarification of requirements that have been subject to varying interpretations, particularly requirements around message delivery notifications. This version also clarifies pertinent requirements in the standards underlying the Applicability Statement for Secure Health Transport. Refer to the standard for more details about the improvements it includes. [see also [80 FR 62679](#)]

- Testing for this criterion will require the processing of invalid test cases that frequently occur in real-world situations so that Security/Trust Agents (STAs) can demonstrate error handling abilities, including handling XDM packages and message disposition.
- As specified in § 170.550(j), an ONC-ACB can only issue a certification to a Health IT Module for § 170.315(h)(1) if the Health IT Module's certification also includes § 170.315(b)(1). For example, if Developer X seeks certification to (b)(1) and (h)(1) with its homegrown integrated health information service provider (HISP) solution, then their ONC-ACB can issue a certificate with (h)(1) included. Likewise, if Developer X seeks certification to (b)(1) and partners with/integrates a third party HISP for (h)(1) consistent with the “[relied upon software](#)” paradigm, then their ONC-ACB can issue a certificate with (h)(1) included. To note, in this instance, the certification would be specific to Developer X and the third party HISP. Each developer that would want to work with the third party HISP in a similar manner would need to seek the same type of relied upon software certification. Thus, HISPs may want to consider certifying to § 170.315(h)(2), which would not require separate testing/certifications with each developer certified to § 170.315(b)(1).
- Consistent with the Implementation Guide for Delivery Notification in Direct, ONC's policy intent is that the receiving HISP must provide delivery notification messages either when it is also the sending HISP, or when it is specifically requested to do so by the sending HISP. A HISP is not compelled to request delivery notifications, but a certified HISP is required to produce them if requested.

Technical outcome – The health IT can electronically transmit (send and receive) health information to a 3rd party which must be formatted only as a “wrapped” message using the Applicability Statement for Secure Health Transport, Version 1.2.

- For certification to this criterion, ONC has made it a requirement to send and receive messages in only “wrapped” format even though the specification allows use of “unwrapped” messages. This requirement will further improve interoperability among Security/Trust Agents (STAs), while having minor development impact on health IT developers. [see also [80 FR 62679](#)]

Technical outcome – The health IT can electronically transmit (send and receive) health information to a 3rd party using Direct in accordance with the Implementation Guide (IG) for Delivery Notification in Direct, Version 1.0.

- The IG for Delivery Notification in Direct, Version 1.0, June 29, 2012 functionality supports interoperability and exchange, particularly for both sending and receiving parties. It provides guidance for enabling HISPs to provide a high level of assurance to senders that a message has arrived at its destination, a necessary component to interoperability. The IG also outlines the various

exception flows that result in compromised message delivery and the mitigation actions that should be taken by STAs to provide success and failure notifications to the sending system. [see also [80 FR 62729](#)]

- For Delivery Notification in Direct, the capability to send and receive health information must be in accordance with the standard specified in § 170.202(e)(1).

Regulation Text

§ 170.315 (h)(1) Direct Project—

(i) Applicability Statement for Secure Health Transport.

Able to send and receive health information in accordance with the standard specified in § 170.202(a)(2), including formatted only as a “wrapped” message.

(ii) Delivery Notification in Direct.

Able to send and receive health information in accordance with the standard specified in § 170.202(e)(1).

Standards & References

The following standards are referenced within the certification criteria for:

§ 170.315(h)(1) Direct Project

§ 170.202(a)(2)

[ONC Applicability Statement for Secure Health Transport, Version 1.2](#) 

Referenced in the Following:

- Paragraph (h)(1)(i)

SVAP-approved Versions:

[Direct Project: ONC Applicability Statement for Secure Health Transport](#) 

§ 170.202(e)(1)

[ONC Implementation Guide for Delivery Notification in Direct](#) 

Referenced in the Following:

- Paragraph (h)(1)(ii)

Certification Dependencies

Dependent Criteria

An ONC-ACB can only issue a certification to a Health IT Module for this criterion at § 170.315(h)(1) if the Health IT Module’s certification also includes § 170.315(b)(1) “Transitions of care.”

§ 170.405

Real World Testing

Products certified to this criterion must complete requirements outlined for the Real World Testing Conditions and Maintenance of Certification.

Note: Enforcement discretion has been issued for CY 2025–2026. Refer to the [Enforcement Discretion Notices](#) for full details.

Privacy and Security

This certification criterion was adopted at § 170.315(h)(1). As a result, an ONC Authorized Certification Body (ONC-ACB) must ensure that a product presented for certification to a § 170.315(h) criterion includes the privacy and security criteria (adopted in § 170.315(d)) within the overall scope of the certificate issued to the product.

- The privacy and security criteria (adopted in § 170.315(d)) do not need to be explicitly tested with this specific paragraph (h) criterion unless it is the only criterion for which certification is requested.
- As a general rule, a product presented for certification only needs to be tested once to each applicable privacy and security criterion (adopted in § 170.315(d)) so long as the health IT developer attests that such privacy and security capabilities apply to the full scope of capabilities included in the requested certification. However, exceptions exist for § 170.315(e)(1) “View, download, and transmit to 3rd party (VDT)” and (e)(2) “Secure messaging,” which are explicitly stated.
- § 170.315(d)(2)(i)(C) is not required if the scope of the Health IT Module does not have end-user device encryption features.

For more information on the approaches to meet these Privacy and Security requirements, please download the Privacy and Security CCG below:

Approaches:

If choosing Approach 1 • Authentication, access control, and authorization (§ 170.315(d)(1)) • Auditable events and tamper-resistance (§ 170.315(d)(2)) • Audit reports (§ 170.315(d)(3)) • Encrypt authentication credentials (§ 170.315(d)(12))	If choosing Approach 2 For each applicable privacy and security certification criterion not certified for Approach 1, the health IT developer may certify using system documentation that is sufficiently detailed to enable integration such that the Health IT Module has implemented service interfaces for each applicable privacy and security certification criterion that enable the
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- [Multi-factor authentication \(MFA\) \(§ 170.315\(d\)\(13\)\)](#).

Health IT Module to access external services necessary to meet the requirements of the privacy and security certification criterion. Please see the *21st Century Cures Act: Interoperability, Information Blocking, and the ONC Health IT Certification Program Final Rule* at [85 FR 25710](#) for additional clarification.

Design and Performance

The following design and performance certification criteria (adopted in § 170.315(g)) must also be certified in order for the product to be certified.

- [Quality management system \(§ 170.315\(g\)\(4\)\)](#): When a single quality management system (QMS) is used, the QMS only needs to be identified once. Otherwise, the QMS' need to be identified for every capability to which it was applied.
- [Accessibility-centered design \(§ 170.315\(g\)\(5\)\)](#): When a single accessibility-centered design standard is used, the standard only needs to be identified once. Otherwise, the accessibility-centered design standards need to be identified for every capability to which they were applied; or, alternatively, the developer must state that no accessibility-centered design was used.
- [Transitions of care \(§ 170.315\(b\)\(1\)\)](#): An ONC-ACB can only issue a certification to a Health IT Module for this criterion at § 170.315(h)(1) if the Health IT Module's certification also includes § 170.315(b)(1) "Transitions of care."

Certification Companion Guide Changelog

The following changelog applies to:

§ 170.315(h)(1) Direct Project

Revision History

Version

1.0

Description of Change

Initial publication

Version Date

03-11-2024

Version

1.1

Description of Change

Added update to Certification Dependencies section to reflect recent Real World Testing enforcement discretion notice.

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07-23-2025